

KF43 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

I hope that you have taken a few minutes each day to practice **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. You may discover that this technique relaxes your body and refreshes your mind. In our stressful world, we all need to learn how to calm our creaturely reactions of fight or flight. We all have work to do, and we want to enjoy the benefits of our work. Techniques that help us to both enjoy our work and work more productively make our lives satisfying and a lot more fun.

Let’s begin with a body scan to connect our minds to our wise and marvelous bodies. Assume a meditation posture and breathe naturally for twenty seconds, allowing your body to regulate your breath. *(Pause for 20 seconds)*

Now turn your attention to your feet and ankles. What sensations do you notice there? *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Take a deep breath and move your attention to your calves and knees. Do you notice discomfort, pain, or perhaps twitching? Breathe and observe. Try to relax on the exhale. *(Pause of 20 seconds)*

Now begin to observe your thighs and hips. What do you notice? On the exhale, release with the breath any tension or discomfort you find there. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Move your attention to your torso. Scan your abdomen, chest, and back. Observe, and then release with the breath any tension you might find. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Now scan your neck and shoulders, arms and hands. Breathe, adjust, and release. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Observe your face. Breathe and relax any tightness or tension you find. *(Pause 20 seconds)*

Begin **Alternate Nostril Breathing**, switching nostrils on the exhale. You can breathe naturally, or you might use the **Three-Part Breath** or the **3-Minute Breathing Space**.¹ Practice for three minutes. I will give you one-minute markers. *(Pause for 3 minutes announcing each minute as it passes)*

And pause. It is beneficial to begin your meditation practice with a few minutes of **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. This breathing technique can also help to clear your mind for work and creativity and to calm your body for sleep.

Our hymn for KF Confession 10 is *O Worship the King*. This hymn praises God for the care that He provides for us through the flow of the Creation.

Thy bountiful care, what tongue can recite?
It breathes in the air, it shines in the light;
It streams from the hills, it descends to the plain,
And sweetly distills in the dew and the rain.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

We are reminded in KF Confession 10 that in order to actualize our potential we have to honor our real limitations:

We honor our limitations and seek lives of gratitude.

WE, W-E, is a nurturing support group for parents.³ In the group’s 1989 newsletter we read:

Becoming who we truly are capable of becoming in the fullest sense could be called the journey of life. Such an on-going, ever-expanding art eludes a tight description and perhaps can only be hinted at as the art of simultaneously being and becoming . . . The person who is adept at becoming will not always be described as happy but will often handle both the joy and the pain of life with acceptance and grace.

Quotes like these help us define the characteristics of the True Self—a fulfilled creature who is both being and becoming at the same time while gracefully accepting the joy and the pain of a real life.

Last week, Nancy introduced the tool of doing the MATH—M-A-T-H. Before beginning any new enterprise, we do the MATH and consider whether we have the Money, Abilities, Time, and Health to accomplish our goals. When we make decisions about our lives, we are setting priorities. Oriented priorities acknowledge that we have limited resources, and by doing the MATH we honor the limitations of those resources.

You cannot do it all, be it all, experience it all, and have it all, but the market economy wants to enslave you by making you believe that you can. Your fear of missing out becomes a primary motivation for playing the Idol’s game of limitless possibilities. This game deceives you into believing that you can overlook or push through real limitations—but your real limitations will always win in the end. The search for the *Glory of Me!* is a kind of premeditated disappointment that invites self-hate and leaves you feeling chronically discontented with your life.

In any area of the MATH, we can inherit debt from others or fall into debt by overextending ourselves. As

a result, we find ourselves with fewer resources for doing what is really important. Perhaps you are in debt today—whether to your money, your abilities, your time, or your health. In the Proverbs we learn that the debtor is the lender’s slave, and if you go into debt in any area of the MATH, you will find yourself enslaved.⁴ As a slave, you are no longer the driving power in your life; you are forced to submit to the will of your taskmasters. Your unrealistic choices create debt, and with debt come self-generated limitations that you and others must then accommodate. You might actually choose to go into debt to avoid your real glory and the opportunity to explore your real potential. When we are in debt, we are like children entangled in a net that must be cut away before we can explore the fascinating house into which we were born.

The consequences of debt are perhaps best understood in the context of money. No matter how much money we have, we need to handle it as a limitation. Money is a finite resource, which, if used poorly, creates destructive limitations in other areas of the MATH. Budgeting programs can help us maintain our financial priorities. YNAB, an acronym for You Need A Budget, is an effective online budgeting tool for managing uncomplicated financial circumstances.⁵ It costs a minimal amount, and there are trial options. The Dave Ramsey course, known as the Financial Peace University, has helped many people find financial freedom from the slavery of debt. You might also explore a free budgeting tool at www.mint.com. Find out what works for you. If your finances are complicated or your resources are extensive, you might employ a professional to ground you in the reality of what your money is for and to help you be faithful to your mission. Too much money can deceive you into ignoring other areas of the MATH, causing you to go into debt in those areas. For example, if you can afford to buy expensive products and health treatments to support your lifestyle and yet continue to ignore your body’s needs, you will eventually find yourself in debt to your health.

It’s in the Idol’s best interests to resist your efforts to keep track of money and learn how to use financial resources wisely. Your Idol wants you to feel anxious about money and will encourage you to use money to support its shoulds and claims. The anxious emotions of need and greed pressure you to return to the Idol’s culture of compulsive spending, snatching, and hoarding, all of which lead to stagnation and misorientation. With a budget, however, your True Self will have the freedom to explore money within the limitations of reality. You can then learn to circulate your financial resources confidently by earning, spending, saving, and giving.

You will never wear a petite if you are tall, nor can you change your race or genetics; and if you are a man, you cannot become a woman. But within the real and fixed limitations of your design, you have a mission, and you can grow. As you grow, so do your possibilities, and you may find that some of the limitations that at one time you believed to be fixed are now stretching or have even disappeared. Choices that honor your MATH today will lead to more flexibility tomorrow. What may not be possible for you now may become possible in your future. Remember ASAP: ask God and others for help; simplify your life; adventure into opportunities that will stretch your limitations; set your priorities according to the money, abilities, time, and health that are actually yours today. Then make courageous, oriented, real choices that may require some endurance but will cultivate your potential in Christ. A more flexible tomorrow won’t materialize by magic, but it might seem like magic when God meets you and supports you in your oriented efforts.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, show me how to stretch my limitations. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let’s look at a prayer from **Proverbs 30:7–9** in Nancy’s paraphrase, which blends together her translations of the original Hebrew and Greek texts.

⁷I have asked You, Lord, for two things. Do not withhold this favor before I die. ⁸Keep useless idolatry and deceitful business at a safe distance from me. Grant neither deprivation nor excess. Feed me with the bite-size morsels that are my portion and appropriate for my current level of development, teaching me mature self-sufficiency. ⁹For if You don’t do this, I might become filled with deceitful ideas and say to myself, “I am not accountable to anyone.” Or, I might become an impoverished outcast and steal from others, using Your authority deceptively.

Take a deep breath.

We see in this prayer two requests—and only two! That’s so simple! The first request is to be set apart into truth and remain connected to reality. The skill of recognizing real evidence and acting on proven principles protects us from deceiving ourselves and being deceived by others. Truth presents one of our great limitations. We cannot stretch the limitations of truth to fit our idealized judgments about how things should be. When we twist the truth or make up a story that supports our judgments and illusions, we are deceiving ourselves. Our misplaced loyalty to our beliefs about what life *should* be prevents us from recognizing what is real. We must then use our precious energy to hide the truth both from ourselves and from others. When reality can no longer be avoided, we must spend more resources cleaning up the mess that we’ve created because we ignored the limitations of truth in the first place.

Let’s assume that in an effort to survive you have become adept at deceiving both yourself and others and are now, consciously or unconsciously, using that skill whenever your pride system is threatened. Your story about threat justifies your choice to deceive. If you want God to protect you from deception, whether in yourself or in others, you will have to learn to live in the truth. We need to develop the courage to deal in truth rather than take refuge in deception, which is one of the cheap habitual shortcuts that our Idol uses to calm our fear and restore our pride. Acting on real evidence and proven principles guides back into the path of orientation energies that we have formerly used for deception. KF training teaches you how to live in reality and gives you tools that help you cooperate with God as He works to keep you safe from deception and lies. If you want to give up the whole world of deceit and experience God’s protection, you must learn to live in the truth. That is a limitation.

The second request in this prayer concerns wealth—wealth in money, abilities, time, and health. You can ask God to teach you how to be content with what is offered to you in your present circumstances. Those circumstances are your portion, and they present real limitations that are specifically designed to help you cultivate your own development. Your ongoing training opportunity is to learn how to function productively within those real limitations. As you learn to manage your real limitations, you will forge the courage and authority that you need to access your true inheritance.

Right now, let's pray and make these two requests to God:

My God and Creator, help me learn to live in the truth so that You can protect me from the fallout of deceit. Feed me with bits of experience that are appropriate for my level of development and teach me how to look after myself. I don't want to extend beyond what I can handle and then wander into the deceptions of my Idol Self, believing that I can be independent from You. On the other hand, I don't want to feel starved or deprived and then find myself in the grip of compulsive needs. I might then be tempted to claim Your authority and judge others as responsible for my suffering. I may even want to blame You!

Take a deep breath.

Compulsive needs are the consequence of the debt we owe to God and to our own soul. Perhaps we don't know that we can actually redeem our debts through oriented living, or perhaps we may simply prefer the habitual shortcuts of snatching and impoverishing ourselves and others. As you learn to use your resources to pay off the debts to your MATH, you will discover that the rate of return is much greater than you can imagine.

We are asking God for a healthy balance between more than enough and more than we can handle. We want to honor our material existence and its real limitations. We do not want to be driven by imagined limitations that justify our compulsive needs and greed.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Guardian of my soul, keep deception far from me and feed me with the portion that is appropriate for me today. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an uncomfortable area of your life that is your portion today. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you consider an uncomfortable area of your life that is your portion today, how does it feel? (Pause) Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold your experience in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push away or justify

thoughts and feelings, or to make up a virtue story. Observe whatever tension you may be feeling as you *consider this uncomfortable area of your life*. (Pause) Give yourself permission now to explore without judgment, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider this uncomfortable area of your life that is your portion*. What sensations are there? (Pause) For example, you might recognize what unfairness or longing feels like in your body. You might recognize courage or curiosity. (Pause) If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this uncomfortable area of your life*. (Pause) What do you believe when you *consider this uncomfortable area*? What judgments do you want to make? (Pause) Do you want to punish or blame yourself, others, or God? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. (Pause for 10 seconds)

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to safely explore something uncomfortable.
- Welcome the Counselor, the Holy Spirit, who comforts you with truth.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. (Pause for 10 seconds)

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁶

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I explore my portion, I let go of the longing to force and control.
- As I explore my portion, I let go of the longing for admiration and affection.
- As I explore my portion, I let go of the longing for security and comfort.
- As I explore my portion, I let go of the longing for my imagined outcomes. (Pause for 30 seconds)

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together for training and healing. Hold us in the power of this new direction as You guide us within our real limitations. Help us do our MATH this week as we co-labor with You to

reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*The NHG book study has begun. We hope that you will join us in the study to develop your own understanding. You might also participate in karis by returning a gift of facilitation to support the new students.

*(*Except in the Jubilee Year)*

¹ Zindel Segal, J. Mark G. Williams, and John D. Teasdale, *Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy for Depression* (New York: Guilford Press, 2013), 208. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² *O Worship the King* by Robert Grant (1779–1838), www.youtube.com/watch?v=RAyKmYD2Zg8.

³ WE is an organization founded by Jean Illsley Clark.

⁴ Prov. 22:7.

⁵ www.youneedabudget.com/.

⁶ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.